Penna, spada e lingua

Pre-Reading

Opera naturale è ch'uom favella:
Ma così o così, natura lascia
Poi fare a voi, secondo che v'abbella.

Dante, *Paradiso* XXVI, on the title page of Papanti, 1875

❧

The question

This project explores a single but complicated question: did Italian unification upend the peninsula's linguistic diversity, replacing hundreds of geographically distinctive dialects with a homogenous Italian? We'll chart two key forces over five rooms: the Risorgimento, which wove disparate states into a single Kingdom between 1859 and 1870, and the Questione della lingua, a centuries-old debate over what form of Italian is proper for writing and which for speaking.

Our sources

As we begin, here's a quick note on our sources. The secondary sources are rich and reasonably comprehensive. Written in English and Italian between 1942 and today, they range from classic studies to recent scholarship, and they don't always agree. The primary sources are a bit leaner, offering us a few threads of insight that we can incorporate into a tapestry. Whenever you're engaging with period voices, ask yourself who or what is missing.

Sala 1 di 5

Prima dell'Italia

Before Italy · to 1796

Italy would not exist as a state until 1861. Until 1796, individual states divided the peninsula into republics, tyrannies, imperial holdings, and more. Educated people spoke a variety of Italian derived from Florentine/Tuscan, largely due to the influence of Dante, Petrarch and Boccaccio (Le Tre Corone) on all subsequent authors. Most everyday people (and most educated people in their everyday lives) spoke a dialect.

> For centuries Italy's political geography had been shaped by rivalries between major European dynastic powers, but it was not until the nineteenth century that demands for political change within the individual Italian states began to be linked to broader projects for political independence or unification. However, the two were never the same and there was strong support for alternative federal solutions.
>
> (Davis 2000)

> During the period following Dante's lifetime, the use of Florentine as a literary language was spread, despite the political disunity of Italy, by Tuscan activity and supremacy in two fields: literary and economic. The work of the great three—Dante, Petrarch, and Boccaccio—had established a corpus of material for literary imitation; and Tuscan and especially Florentine manufacturing, commercial and banking activity carried Tuscan speech and literature to the rest of Italy.
>
> The year when the first gold florin was coined (1252) was a date of fully as great importance in the spread of Florentine speech as the date of any single work of literature.
>
> (Hall 4)

Sala 2 di 5

Sussurri

Whispers · 1796–1847

French and Austrian powers would reignite and extinguish dreams of an Italian nation for over half a century. So long as occupying armies and local rulers of foreign extraction (especially from dynastic families like the Habsburgs) remained on Italian soil, radical ideas like independence and unification were political nonstarters. Within the Italian states, opinions on an ideal form of government varied: some dreamed of a popular insurrection that would overthrow the existing rulers and found a republic; some imagined a confederation headed by the Holy See; some sought unification beneath a particular monarch; and so forth. Beneath a veil of repression, artists, authors, musicians, actors, and other creatives shared such visions through their work.

> Since censorship and police surveillance made any form of open political debate impossible, literature, painting, and music were evocative vehicles for nationalist aspirations, but as soon as these were translated into specific political programs it became clear that nationalism was more likely to divide than unite Italians.
>
> (Davis 2001)

Sala 3 di 5

La rivoluzione e il Regno

Revolution & the Kingdom · 1848–1870

Following the disappointments of 1848 (a year of failed revolutions across Europe), the Piedmontese took on a leadership role. Assisted by French allies and Giuseppe Garibaldi's forces, the peninsula was gradually "united" under Victor Emmanuel II. When the Kingdom of Italy was first proclaimed, Italy had already experienced two Wars of Independence; a third would follow in 1866. Allied with Prussia, which defeated Austria that year, the Kingdom annexed Venetia; in 1870, after French troops left Rome, it took the city from the Pope, creating a fractious but consolidated Italian state. Post-unification, Italy was far from democratic: fewer than 2 percent of Italians could vote in 1861. The papacy strained against the Kingdom; many Southern Italians actively resisted.

> The transition to unification proved difficult, however, as the industrialized Northern Italy was disdainful of the Mezzogiorno, which presented many economic liabilities and was furthermore infamous for rampant brigandage (robbery and plunder), which was conducted as a form of political resistance.
>
> ("Italy, 1789–1914")

> The Italian people, however, had played little direct part in the Risorgimento and had little part in the new kingdom since fewer than 2 percent of the population met the literacy or property requirements needed to vote in 1861. The elites were also divided. Until the end of his life in 1872, Mazzini—who believed the triumph of the Piedmontese monarchy to be a travesty of the ideals of the Risorgimento—was under sentence of death for treason while Pope Pius IX had declared himself the prisoner of the Vatican, denounced the new state as the negation of God, and forbade practicing Catholics from voting or holding public office.
>
> (Davis 2004)

Sala 4 di 5

Creare gli «italiani»

Creating "Italians" · 1861–1886

Within the Kingdom, cultural unification proved an even more daunting task than mere state formation. How many Italians spoke "Italian"? Who would be educated, where, and in which form of Italian? What would happen to regional dialects as a result? The sources we'll examine will not arrive at a consensus on these questions.

> Unification proved to be a point of departure, not arrival [. . .].
>
> (Davis 2004)

> It was only when the post-Napoleonic era brought with it an effective desire for political unification, and eventual achievement of that aim, that the old problem debated in the Questione della Lingua, the extension of a single standard language to all of Italy, was solved.
>
> (Hall 9)

Sala 5 di 5

Le conseguenze

The Fallout · 1886–today

Cuore is an episode, but not the end of the story. Italian continued to spread via schools, the armed forces, and new technologies like the radio and television. Government policy on dialects would shift several times, and other countries would face similar questions.

> In more recent years, linguistic unification has been further advanced by increased regional intercommunication, by schools, by the radio, and by military training. [. . .] it must also be remembered, though, that standard Italian, although based on Florentine, is not without dialectal elements as well [. . .].
>
> (Hall 9–10)

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